

Spotify India — User Engagement & Listening Time

Business Requirements Document (Simplified) · Problem framing only — no solutions

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This is the plain-language version of the BRD. It follows the same sections as the full document and defines the problem we’re solving and why — **not** the solution. Ideas and features come later; first we agree on the problem. Figures marked **[M1]** come from Milestone 1 research.

1 Executive Summary Snapshot

India is one of Spotify’s **biggest audiences but smallest earners**. Our strongest lever is **engagement** — how much time people spend listening. It’s a simple chain: **more listening → people stay → staying is what earns money** (ads for free users, subscriptions for premium).

Today, many Indian listeners aren’t building the daily habit — the music can feel off (wrong language, mood, or moment), the app heavy on data, or free options like YouTube ‘good enough.’ This document defines that problem so design, engineering, and strategy start from the same page. **[M1: Spotify India listening-time findings]**

2 Project Description

What this is: a shared, plain-language definition of Spotify India’s engagement / listening-time problem, building on Milestone 1 research.

What we’re trying to achieve. The **business goal**: earn more and lose fewer users from a huge audience. The **product goal**: more **time spent listening** per person (more active days, longer sessions, more often). In one line: the product goal (listening time) is how we reach the business goal (revenue + retention). Chasing installs or sign-ups alone measures vanity, not value.

3 Project Scope (In-Scope / Out-of-Scope)

In-scope	Out-of-scope
- Defining the engagement / listening-time problem for India. Free and premium users; mobile-first. - Segments, personas, journeys and Jobs-to-be-Done. - Problem-focused requirements, KPIs, assumptions.	- Solutions, features, or UI (later milestones). - Pricing / packaging or content-licensing changes. - Markets outside India; backend re-architecture. - Marketing creative or vendor/tool selection.

4 Business Drivers

Why this is urgent now:

- A **large but low-earning audience** — growth needs engagement, not just sign-ups.
- Retention economics**: without a listening habit, cheaply-acquired users churn to free rivals.

- **Competition for attention** (JioSaavn, Wynk, YouTube Music, Apple/Amazon, and free YouTube) — it's a share-of-ear battle.
- **Revenue is tied to listening:** ad income scales with time spent; premium value and conversion depend on habitual usefulness.

5 Current Process (Spotify Engagement Patterns and Listening Behaviors)

How people listen today:

- Mostly on the **free tier**, on **budget Android phones**, often on limited data / patchy internet.
- Music is usually a **companion** to something else — commute, work, chores, workouts, sleep.
- **Regional-language** repertoire drives a lot of listening; relevance to a user's language matters.
- When recommendations miss (language / mood / moment), people fall back to search, known songs, or competitors — and sessions get shorter.

India isn't one audience — it differs by **city vs town**, **free vs paid**, **age**, and **language**. Three quick stand-ins:

Person	In plain words	What they really want (their 'job')
Aditya Gen Z, city, free	College student, metro, budget phone, limited data, likes what's trending.	"On my commute or with friends, effortless, on-trend music — don't make me search."
Meera Millennial, Tier-2, free	Working professional, smaller city, prefers her regional language, watches data.	"While I work or do chores, familiar regional music that just works and saves data."
Rohan Millennial, city, premium	Busy urban professional, several devices, playlists + podcasts.	"When I focus or relax, reliable, spot-on listening across my devices without fiddling."

Where we lose them: weak first-session relevance → no habit; relevance / continuity gaps → fewer, shorter sessions; friction vs 'good-enough free' → they switch.

6 Proposed Process (Framing the Engagement Problem without Prescribing Solutions)

Reframe (no solutions). The goal is to *increase meaningful listening time* by reducing friction across four problem areas: **Relevance** (right content for language, mood, moment), **Access** (data-, device-, network-friendly), **Habit** (coming back and continuing), and **Value** (free and premium clearly worth it).

These four become the **hypotheses we'll test** in Milestone 3 — stated here only to make the problem clear and testable, not to pick a solution.

7 Functional Requirements (Problem-Focused)

The *needs* any future solution must meet (not features):

- Help users **find relevant content easily** — by language, mood, and context.
- Let users **keep and resume** listening across contexts and devices (continuity).
- Work well for **cheap phones, low data, and weak networks**.
- Offer a **free experience worth choosing** over 'good-enough' alternatives.
- Deliver a **relevant first session** to seed the habit early.

- Let the business **measure engagement reliably** (listening time, sessions, retention) by segment.

8 Non-Functional Requirements

- Fast** and smooth on low-to-mid-range Android devices.
- Light on data** and graceful on weak / intermittent connectivity.
- Reliable** and available; consistent offline / online.
- Multilingual** UI and content across Hindi and major regional languages.
- Scales** for peaks (festivals, releases, sale events).
- Private & compliant** with Indian data / content rules; well-instrumented for metrics.

9 Assumptions and Constraints

Assumptions: Milestone 1 findings hold; most users start on free; language relevance and affordability matter; listening time is a fair early signal of retention and revenue; usage is mobile-first.

Constraints: low willingness to pay; varied devices and connectivity; catalogue / licensing we can't change here; strong free competition; evolving Indian data rules; cross-team, multi-time-zone working.

10 Success Criteria & KPIs

North Star: Time spent listening (minutes per active user per day). It rolls up: more listening → better retention → more money (ad revenue + premium conversion, higher ARPU / LTV).

The few things we'll watch:

- Listening time** per active user (North Star), by segment.
- Stickiness & sessions:** daily vs monthly actives, sessions/day, session length.
- Retention:** return after 7 and 30 days; churn.
- Money signals:** ad listening hours, free→premium conversion, revenue per user.

Baselines and targets come from Milestone 1 [M1] — set together.

11 Timeline & Milestones

Milestone	Focus	Status
M1 — Research	Market, competitor & user research; why engagement matters	Done
M2 — BRD (this)	Problem definition, scope, framing, KPIs	In review
M3 — Discovery	Test the four hypotheses; user research; sizing	Upcoming
M4 — PRD & design	Solution requirements & design (solutions start here)	Upcoming

12 Stakeholders

Product (owns the framing), **Design & UX Research** (users, personas, journeys), **Engineering** (feasibility, performance, data), **Data / Analytics** (metrics, baselines), **Marketing / Growth**, **Content & Regional** teams (language relevance), and **Strategy / Leadership** (business goals).

13 (Optional) Cost & Benefit

Cost of doing nothing: continued low listening time → weak retention → churn to free rivals; suppressed ad inventory and premium conversion; lost ground in a strategic market. **Benefit of solving it:** more listening → stronger retention → more ad and subscription revenue → better ARPU / LTV and a defensible position in India. Detailed financials to be modelled after validation **[M1 / M3]**.

14 Glossary

Term	Plain meaning
Engagement	How actively people use the app — here, mostly how much they listen.
North Star metric	The one number that best shows we're delivering value: listening time .
KPI tree	A simple map of how listening time rolls up into retention, then money.
Retention / churn	How many people keep coming back vs how many leave.
ARPU / LTV	Revenue from an average user — per period, and over their whole time with us.
Job-to-be-Done	The real reason someone plays music — the 'job' they hire it for.

15 References

Directional market context draws on public sources — IFPI *Global Music Report*, FICCI–EY *Indian M&E Report*, RedSeer streaming reports, and Spotify investor / press materials — plus the reader's Milestone 1 research. **Cite the exact reports / editions used in Milestone 1 for every specific figure.**

16 Appendix

Data to fill from Milestone 1 [M1]: Spotify India listening-time baselines by segment; free vs premium split; urban/rural and language mix; competitor engagement benchmarks; market size, growth and ARPU. Every **[M1]** marker in this document shows where your numbers and citations go.

The bottom line: if we help people listen a little more — more relevant, easier to access, worth the habit — retention and revenue follow. That's the whole game. Solutions come next; agreeing on this problem comes first.